

Feeding your baby

Breastfeeding provides your baby with the best nutritional start in life and has a range of other benefits. If you decide to bottle-feed, you can also be confident that your baby will thrive. The key to both methods is preparation.

The benefits of breastfeeding

Breastfeeding is the perfect first food for your baby; it contains all the nutrients your baby needs and works on a supply-and-demand basis, so that as your baby feeds, your body responds by producing more milk. Breast milk is thought to reduce a baby's risk of developing an allergic condition, such as asthma and eczema, to make childhood obesity and diabetes less likely, and it may reduce the long-term risk of heart disease.

Breastfeeding also provides benefits for you. It helps your uterus contract to its pre-pregnancy shape more quickly. It helps you get back into shape quicker since your body uses additional energy to produce breast milk, and it reduces your risk of getting breast and ovarian cancer.

Lastly, breastfeeding helps you and your baby to bond both physically and emotionally.

When your milk comes in

In the first few days your breasts produce colostrum, a watery substance that contains essential nutrients and antibodies that help your baby fight off infections such as those of the ear, chest, and gastrointestinal tract.

At around day three, or sometimes a bit later, you will start to produce milk, which contains all the nutrients your baby needs. Your breasts may feel uncomfortably full and tender at this time, and you'll need to make sure they're properly emptied at each feeding to prevent them from becoming engorged (see [Tuning in](#)).

Successful breastfeeding

Despite the fact that breastfeeding is a natural process, it can sometimes prove difficult. Getting comfortable before a feeding, positioning your baby well, and ensuring that they [latch on](#) properly, are all prerequisites for successful feeding.

For your baby to latch on to the breast properly, it's important that you're both positioned well. Ensure that you're comfortable and that your back is well supported; using cushions for support may be helpful. You may find sitting and cradling your baby at chest level is comfortable with their tummy facing your tummy. Or you could try a football hold with your baby under your arm. Some women find it helpful to lie on their side to latch their baby on. You'll soon discover which positions suit you best and will gradually gain confidence in your ability to feed.